# Inca Trail Tour Options: Which One Is R

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trek, there's a route to match your travel style.

The tricky part? Comparing your options and making a decision. This guide does the hard work for you. We'll compare every Inca Trail tour we offer, so you can quickly figure out which adventure fits your time, fitness level, budget, and bucket list.

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THE WIÑAY WAYNA ARCHAEOLOGICAL SITE ON THE INCA TRAIL.

## Why There Isn't Just One Inca Trail Tour

When people talk about the Inca Trail, they're usually thinking of the famous 4-day hike to Machu Picchu. It's the original route, and there's no denying it's *very* special.

But not everyone wants to spend four days in the Andes in the same fashion.

Some travelers only have time for a shorter adventure. Others want a quieter, more personal experience or prefer combining two famous treks into one unforgettable trip (yes, it's very possible). That's exactly why there are several Inca Trail tours to choose from.

The best tour isn't the same for everyone. It all comes down to what kind of adventure you're looking for.

## Quick Comparison of All Inca Trail Tours

## Inca Trail Tours at a Glance

| Tour | Days | Distance | Difficulty | Best For | Book Ahead |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Classic Inca Trail | 4 | 27.3 miles / 44 km | Moderate to Challenging | The full Inca Trail experience | 6–8 months |
| Short Inca Trail | 2 | 7.5 miles / 12 km | Moderate | Travelers short on time | 4–6 months |
| Inca Trail Challenge | 1 | 5.6 miles / 9 km | Moderate | Hiking part of the trail in a single day | 4–6 months |
| Private Inca Trail | 4 | 27.3 miles / 44 km | Moderate to Challenging | Couples, families, and private groups | 6–8 months |
| Salkantay Trek and Inca Trail | 7 | 42.9 miles / 69 km | Moderate to Challenging | Two iconic treks in one trip | 6–8 months |
| Salkantay Trek and Inca Trail Short | 6 | 53.9 miles / 86.8 km | Moderate to Challenging | Travelers wanting both routes in less time | 4–6 months |
| Lares Trek and Inca Trail | 5 | 25.2 miles / 40.5 km | Moderate to Challenging | Culture, mountains, and the Inca Trail | 4–6 months |
| Ancascocha Trek and Inca Trail | 5 | 37.9 miles / 61 km | Moderate to Challenging | Experienced hikers looking | 4–6 months |

trails

Now let's take a closer look at what makes each one different.

# Classic Inca Trail 4 Days: The Complete Inca Trail Experience

If you've been dreaming about hiking to Machu Picchu for years, you may well have pictured yourself walking this exact route.

The **Inca Trail** is the original journey to the Modern World Wonder (literally, the route follows Incan paths that were once part of the Andean road system). Over four days, you'll hike along ancient stone paths, cross mountain passes, explore fascinating archaeological sites, and finish with the famous walk through the Sun Gate (Inti Punku) before arriving at Machu Picchu. It's the route that made the Inca Trail in Peru so famous, and it's still the most sought-after experience.

## Classic Inca Trail 4 Days: Quick Facts

- **Duration:** 4 Days
- **Difficulty:** Moderate to Challenging
- **Accommodation:** Camping
- **Best For:** Travelers wanting the complete Inca Trail experience

## Who the Classic Inca Trail Is Best For

This is the tour for travelers who don't want to miss a thing.

If you have four days available and want to experience the original route to Machu Picchu, this is hard to beat. It's especially popular with first-time visitors to Peru, history lovers, and anyone who's always wanted to hike one of the world's most famous trails.

You don't need to be a super athlete, but you should be comfortable with several days of hiking at altitude. We recommend arriving in Cusco a few days before your trek to **acclimatize in the city**.




WARMIWAÑUSCA PASS ON THE INCA TRAIL

## Highlights of the 4-Day Route

One of the best things about the Classic Inca Trail is how much variety it packs into four days.

You'll hike through the cloud forest, tackle high mountain passes, and visit impressive Inca sites that most visitors to Peru never see. Then comes the moment the whole trek builds towards—walking through the Sun Gate and seeing Machu Picchu spread out below you. It truly is a spectacular way to arrive.

## Reasons to Choose This Tour

- You want the complete Inca Trail experience.
- You'd love to visit several Inca archaeological sites along the way.
- Walking into Machu Picchu through the Sun Gate is high on your bucket list.
- You have enough time to enjoy the full journey.

## Reasons It Might Not Be Right for You

camping, another route may suit you better. Permits also sell out quickly, so booking well in advance is a must. They can sell out 8 months in advance in the dry season (May–September).

## Short Inca Trail 2 Days: The Best Option if You're Short on Time

Not everyone has four days to spend hiking to Machu Picchu, and that's where the **Short Inca Trail** comes in. It packs plenty of the magic into just two days, making it one of the most popular Inca Trail tours from Cusco for travelers running on a tighter schedule.

You'll still hike part of the famous trail, visit impressive Inca ruins, see Machu Picchu from the Sun Gate, and explore the site itself the following morning. The biggest difference? No camping and a much shorter commitment.




THE ARCHAEOLOGICAL SITE OF INTI PUNKU (SUN GATE)




THE MACHU PICCHU VIEW FROM SUN GATE (INTI PUNKU)

## Short Inca Trail 2 Days: Quick Facts

- **Duration:** 2 Days

## Who the Short Inca Trail Is Best For

This is a great choice if you're trying to fit a lot into a single trip to Peru.

Maybe you've only got a week in the country. Maybe hiking for four days doesn't sound like your idea of a vacation. Or maybe you just want a taste of the famous trail before reaching Machu Picchu.

Whatever the reason, this itinerary lets you experience the highlights without committing nearly as much time.

## What You Experience on the 2-Day Route

The hike begins much closer to Machu Picchu than the Classic route, but don't mistake "shorter" for "less impressive."

You'll still walk along the original Inca paths, visit the beautiful archaeological site of Wiñay Wayna, and reach Machu Picchu via the Sun Gate, a privilege that relatively few visitors get to enjoy.

After spending the night in Aguas Calientes in a comfy hotel, you'll return to the citadel the following morning for a guided tour.

## Reasons to Choose This Tour

- You have limited time in Peru.
- You'd rather stay in a hotel than camp.
- You still want to arrive through the Sun Gate.
- You like the idea of hiking without tackling four full days.

## Reasons It Might Not Be Right for You

If you've always dreamed of completing the full Inca Trail, you may wish you'd gone for the Classic route instead.

You'll miss the higher mountain passes, the extra archaeological sites, the fun of camping in the Andes, and the feeling of spending several days on one of the world's most famous trails.

We designed the **Inca Trail Challenge** for travelers who want to hike part of the famous route before visiting Machu Picchu but don't have time for a multi-day trek. It's a long day, but one that packs a surprising amount into the itinerary, taking you along the short stretch from KM 104 to Machu Picchu.

## Inca Trail Challenge 1 Day: Quick Facts

- **Duration:** 1 Day
- **Difficulty:** Moderate
- **Accommodation:** None
- **Best For:** Travelers with very limited time

## Who the Inca Trail Challenge Is Best For

This one's made for super busy itineraries. If your Peru plans already include the Sacred Valley, Rainbow Mountain, or another trek, adding four days on the Inca Trail might simply not be possible.

The Challenge gives you the chance to experience part of the legendary trail without having to rearrange your entire trip.

## What You See on the 1-Day Route

You'll hike one of the most scenic sections of the Inca Trail, visit Wiñay Wayna, walk through the Sun Gate, and arrive at Machu Picchu on foot to explore the upper sector and capture that classic postcard photo.

It's a surprisingly rewarding day and proof that you don't always need several nights on the trail to create lasting memories.

## Reasons to Choose This Tour

- You're short on time.
- You'd like to hike part of the Inca Trail.
- You still want that unforgettable walk through the Sun Gate.
- You're not looking for a camping adventure.

camp in the Andes, and visit several archaeological sites over multiple days, you'll probably find yourself wishing you'd booked the Classic trek instead.



TOURISTS IN PHUYUPATAMARKA

## Salkantay and Inca Trail: The Ultimate Trekking Combination

If choosing between the Salkantay Trek and the Inca Trail feels impossible, there's a simple solution: don't.

The **Salkantay and Inca Trail** isn't just two treks stitched together. It combines the scenery of the Salkantay route with the historic final section of the Classic Inca Trail, creating one unforgettable journey to Machu Picchu.

- **Difficulty:** Moderate to challenging
- **Accommodation:** Exclusive Sky Camp and camping
- **Best For:** Experienced hikers wanting to combine two iconic treks






SKY CAMP EXPERIENCES

time, enjoy long days on the trail, and want to experience two iconic routes in one trip, this is hard to beat. Plus, you get to spend a night in our exclusive Sky Camp beneath the towering Salkantay Mountain and Andean night sky.

## What Makes This Trek Unique

Instead of choosing between Peru's two most famous hikes, this tour lets you experience both in one trip.

The adventure begins on the spectacular Salkantay Trek, where you'll hike through dramatic mountain scenery, up to Humantay Lake, and cross the famous Salkantay Pass. Then, you'll join the regulated Classic Inca Trail at Paucarcancha, hiking a section of this legendary route, including Dead Woman's Pass, all the way to Machu Picchu.

That means you get the best of both worlds with the wild landscapes of the Salkantay Trek and the history of the Classic Inca Trail, culminating in an unforgettable walk through the Sun Gate before arriving at Machu Picchu.

## Reasons to Choose This Tour

- You can't decide between the Salkantay Trek and the Inca Trail.
- You enjoy challenging hikes.
- You want one of Peru's most complete trekking experiences.

## Reasons It Might Not Be Right for You

It's longer and tougher, and it requires a bigger time commitment than the other tours. If you're new to multi-day hiking, a shorter option may be more enjoyable. If you simply don't have enough time or want to experience more of the Salkantay route, our 6-day option below might suit you a little better.

# Salkantay Trek and Short Inca Trail: The Best of Both in Less Time

You'll experience the spectacular mountain scenery of the Salkantay Trek before joining the Short Inca Trail for the final stretch to Machu Picchu. It packs a great deal into just 6 days.

## Salkantay Trek and Short Inca Trail: Quick Facts

- **Duration:** 6 Days
- **Difficulty:** Moderate to Challenging
- **Accommodation:** Camping and hotel
- **Best For:** Travelers wanting to experience both the Salkantay Trek and the Inca Trail in less time

## Who This Tour Is Best For

This itinerary is ideal if you want to experience Peru's two most famous trekking routes but can't quite stretch to the 7-day version.

It's still a challenge, but it's a fantastic option for active travelers with slightly tighter schedules.



SUPER JUNGLE DOMES



SUPER JUNGLE DOMES INTERIOR

## What You Experience on Each Route

Picchu.

It's a brilliant balance of mountain scenery, history, and adventure.

### Reasons to Choose This Tour

- You want to experience both iconic routes.
- You have six days available.
- You enjoy a challenge without committing to the longest itinerary.

### Reasons It Might Not Be Right for You

If you've always wanted to complete the entire Classic Inca Trail, or you're looking for a more relaxed trek, another itinerary may suit you better.

## Lares Trek and Short Inca Trail: Culture Meets History

The **Lares Trek and Short Inca Trail** offers something completely different to other routes.

While the scenery is beautiful, it's the local communities that make this route so memorable. You'll pass traditional Andean villages where life still moves at its own pace, and locals follow centuries-old traditions, then join the Short Inca Trail on the way to Machu Picchu.

### Lares Trek and Short Inca Trail: Quick Facts

- **Duration:** 5 Days
- **Difficulty:** Moderate to Challenging
- **Accommodation:** Camping and hotel
- **Best For:** Travelers looking for a mix of culture, mountain scenery, and the Inca Trail

### Who This Tour Is Best For

If meeting local people is just as important as reaching the finish line, this is well worth considering.

It's a great choice for travelers who enjoy learning about local traditions alongside



CAMELIDS ON THE LARES ROUTE

## What You Experience on Each Route

The Lares Trek introduces you to remote villages, peaceful valleys, and life in the Andes before the Short Inca Trail adds the history, ancient stone paths, and dramatic arrival at Machu Picchu. It's a brilliant combination.

## Reasons to Choose This Tour

- You enjoy cultural experiences.
- You want quieter trails.
- You'd like to experience part of the Inca Trail.

## Reasons It Might Not Be Right for You

If your dream has always been hiking the complete Classic Inca Trail, this itinerary may leave you wanting more.

Some people actively avoid crowds. If that's you, keep reading, as the **Ancascocha Trek and Short Inca Trail** could be just what you're looking for.

The Ancascocha Trek is one of Peru's quieter routes, taking you through remote valleys, rural communities, high-mountain scenery, and landscapes that feel wonderfully silent (due to less tourist traffic) before it joins the Short Inca Trail to Machu Picchu.

## Ancascocha Trek and Short Inca Trail: Quick Facts

- **Duration:** 5 Days
- **Difficulty:** Moderate to challenging
- **Accommodation:** Camping and hotel
- **Best For:** Experienced hikers looking for quieter, off-the-beaten-path trails

## Who This Tour Is Best For

This itinerary suits experienced hikers who'd rather swap busy trails for wide-open mountain landscapes. If you like the idea of seeing a different side of Peru before reaching Machu Picchu, it's an excellent option.

## What You Experience on Each Route

The first part of the trek is all about remote scenery, peaceful trails, and witnessing locals living and working off the land much as they have done for centuries. Then, as you join the Short Inca Trail, you'll experience the famous stone pathways before arriving at Machu Picchu through the Sun Gate. You might say it's the best of both worlds.

## Reasons to Choose This Tour

- You enjoy quieter hiking routes.
- You're looking for something a little different.
- You want to combine two incredible trekking experiences.

## Reasons It Might Not Be Right for You



THE ANCASCOCHA ROUTE.

# Should You Upgrade to a Private Inca Trail Tour for a More Personalized Experience?

The route might be the same as the classic trail, but the experience can feel completely different.

Choosing a **Private Inca Trail** means setting your own pace, enjoying more flexibility, and sharing the trail with the people you actually traveled with without trying to keep up with strangers and wondering whether you're slowing everyone down. Sometimes that's worth its weight in hiking snacks.

## Private Inca Trail Tours: Quick Facts

- **Duration:** 4 Days

## Who a Private Inca Trail Tour Is Best For

Private tours suit travelers who value flexibility above all else.

They're especially popular with couples celebrating a special occasion, families hiking together, or groups of friends who'd rather stick together than join a larger crew.

## What Makes a Private Tour Different

The scenery, route, and archaeological sites don't change, but the pace does.

You'll have more freedom throughout the trek, more one-on-one time with your guide, and an itinerary that feels tailored to your group rather than the other way around.

## Reasons to Choose This Tour

- You prefer a more personal experience.
- You're traveling with family or friends.
- You'd like more flexibility on the trail.
- You enjoy having a dedicated guide.

## Reasons It Might Not Be Right for You

If you're traveling solo or hoping to keep costs as low as possible, a group departure is usually the better choice. The experience is still fantastic—you'll simply be sharing it with a few more people.

> ***Traveling as a family?*** *A private tour can be a fantastic option, but it's worth remembering that the Inca Trail isn't suitable for very young children or anyone who isn't prepared for several days of hiking at altitude. If you're bringing children, they should have a good level of fitness and feel comfortable walking for long hours on steep, uneven trails with plenty of stone steps.*

# How to Choose the Right Inca Trail Tour for You

## Choose Based on Your Available Time

- **1 day:** Inca Trail Challenge
- **2 days:** Short Inca Trail
- **4 days:** Classic or Private Inca Trail
- **5–7 days:** Combination treks

## Choose Based on Your Fitness Level

Every Inca Trail tour involves hiking at high altitude, but some are definitely more challenging than others. Here's a quick overview:

- The **Inca Trail Challenge (1 Day)** is a great choice if you're reasonably active. The day involves lots of hiking with many uphill sections and stone steps, but you'll only be on the trail for a day, so you don't need to endure trekking for days on end.
- The **Short Inca Trail** is moderately difficult. You'll still climb stairs, hike at altitude, and spend several hours on the trail, but it's much less demanding than the Classic route.
- The **Classic Inca Trail** (and the private version) require you to hike 27.3 miles / 44 km, so you can expect long hiking days, thousands of steps, steep climbs, like the one up to Dead Woman's Pass, and high altitude conditions at various parts throughout the trek.
- The **combination treks** are generally the most physically demanding because they involve more days of hiking, longer distances, higher elevations, and more elevation gain.

No matter which route you choose, spending a couple of days acclimatizing in Cusco before your trek can make a huge difference.

## Choose Based on Your Budget

Generally speaking, shorter tours cost less, while longer itineraries and private departures come with a higher price tag. Think about what matters most to you. Sometimes an extra day on the trail is worth every penny.

## Choose Based on Your Preferred Comfort Level

The Classic and Private Inca Trail involve camping. The Short Inca Trail includes a hotel stay in Aguas Calientes, making it a good choice if sleeping in a proper bed sounds appealing after a

camps, with both offering a night at our exclusive camp with proper beds.

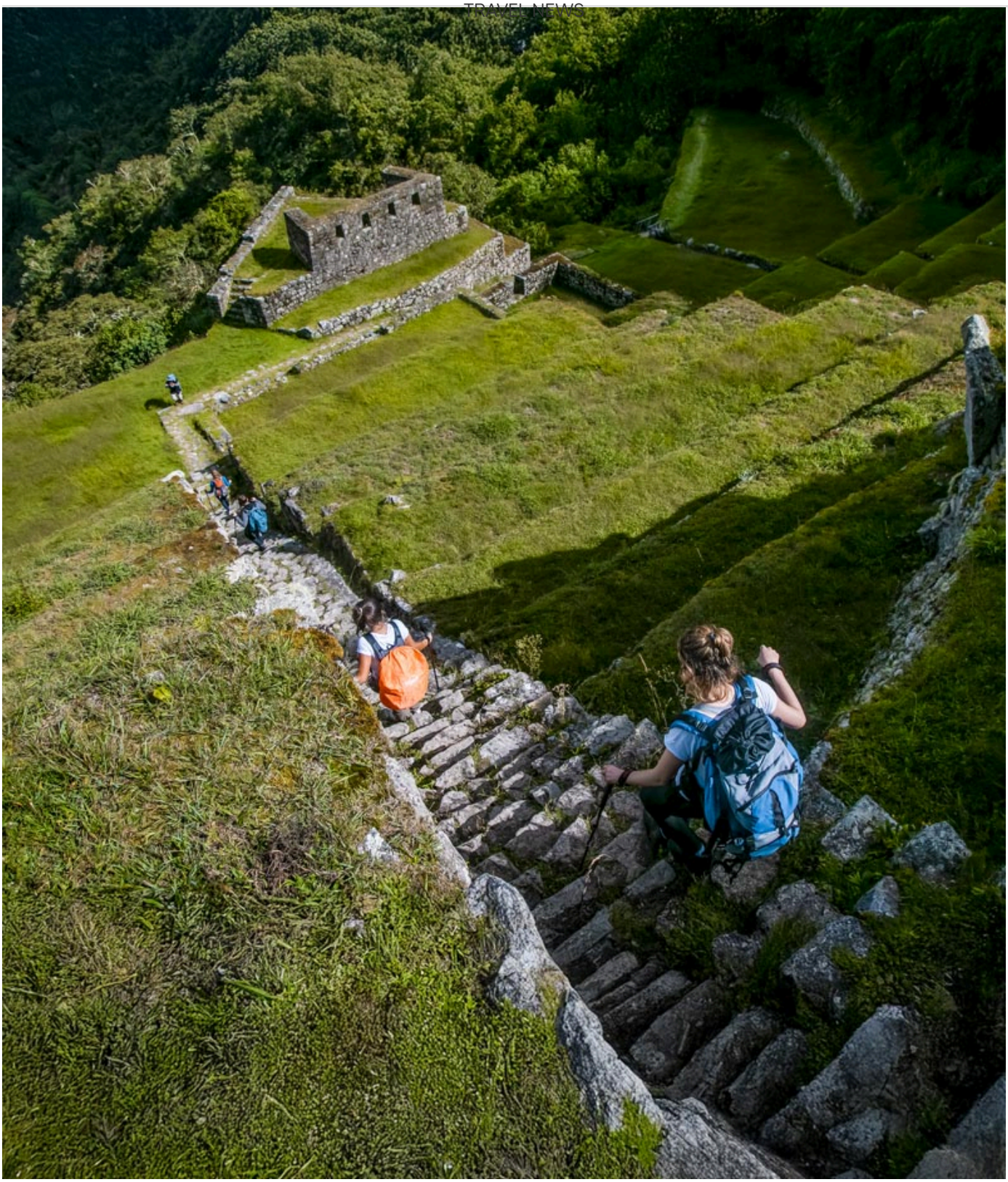
## Choose Based on Whether You Want a Private or Group Tour

Group tours are sociable and often more affordable. Private tours give you more flexibility, your own guide, and a pace that suits your group.

## Choose Based on Permit Availability

One thing you can't leave until the last minute is your permit.

Classic Inca Trail permits are limited and often sell out months ahead, especially during the busiest travel season. If your dates are fixed, booking early gives you the best chance of securing the tour you want.



TOURISTS ON THE STEPS ALONG THE INCA TRAIL



TOURISTS ON THE INCA TRAIL HIKE

# Frequently Asked Questions About Inca Trail Tours

### What Is the Best Inca Trail Tour?

For most travelers, the Classic 4-Day Inca Trail is the standout choice because it offers the complete experience. If you're short on time, the Short Inca Trail is an excellent alternative.

### Which Inca Trail Tour Is Best for Beginners?

The Short Inca Trail is usually shorter and less time-intensive, but still requires preparation for fitness and altitude.

### Is the 2-Day or 4-Day Inca Trail Better?

It depends on your priorities. The 4-day trek gives you the full experience, while the 2-day version is ideal if you're working with a tighter schedule.

### Can You Hike the Inca Trail Without a Guide?

No. Independent hiking isn't allowed, and the government heavily regulates the trail. All visitors must hike with an authorized Inca Trail tour operator and hold an official permit.

### Are Inca Trail Permits Included?

Yes. All Salkantay Trekking Inca Trail tours include the required permits as part of your booking. As soon as you know when you'll travel, you'll need to contact us regarding dates to check whether Inca Trail permits are available.

### Do All Inca Trail Tours End at Machu Picchu?

Yes. Every itinerary ends with a visit to Machu Picchu, one of the Modern Seven Wonders of the World and a UNESCO World Heritage Site, via circuits 1C and 3B, in accordance with current Peruvian government regulations.

### What Is the Best Time of Year to Hike the Inca Trail?

The dry season, from around May to September, usually offers the best hiking conditions, although permits are in highest demand during these months.



TOURISTS AT MACHU PICCHU

## Ready to Choose Your Inca Trail Adventure?

Remember, there's no single "best" Inca Trail tour. It's simply the one that's right for you.

Whether you're dreaming of completing the Classic 4-Day trek, squeezing in the Short Inca Trail during a busy Peru itinerary, or taking on an epic combination adventure, every route has what it takes to become the trip of a lifetime.

The hardest part isn't hiking to Machu Picchu. It's deciding which route gets you there. Once you've made up your mind, Salkantay Trekking is here to help you plan your Andean adventure exactly the way you want.

Attractions of Inca Trail hiking the Inca Trail What is the Inca Trail Where is the Inca Trail Share



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